



**The Honourable Chief Minister Shri Nitish Kumar meeting the Indian National Women's Hockey Team before the exhibition match during the inauguration of the Rajgir Stadium.**

identified as an urgent requirement, with a recommendation to hire at least 300 coaches trained in various disciplines, including those with NIS diplomas. The need to engage sports consultants with decades of experience was also stressed to help in talent scouting, sports administration, and the overall management of sports. Additionally, maintaining a data bank for each athlete, documenting their age, anthropometric details, agility, endurance, and flexibility, will be crucial for future planning.

The plenary sessions underscored the crucial role of Physical Education Teachers (PETs) in schools. PETs need to be sensitised and trained not only to develop at least one sport in their schools but also to have a keen ability to identify inherent talent in children that can be nurtured for further development. Sports incentives and scholarships are critical for ensuring participation from children, especially those from economically disadvantaged backgrounds. The absence of financial security is a significant barrier for parents, and without scholarships or other financial incentives, parents are less likely to encourage their children to pursue sports.

The collaboration between the state, associations, and federations is crucial for the selection, training, and retention of athletes. The state should provide financial

and logistical support to the associations to organise as many competitions as possible. Block-level competitions were also recommended to ensure grassroots participation, with the involvement of school PETs and Panchayat leaders. The principle of "Catch them young but don't kill them young" was discussed, stressing the need for the strategic nurturing of talent over the long term. Winning a few medals at the junior level should not be the final target; the focus should be on ensuring that talent is nurtured to reach high-performance levels for international competitions.

A talent scouting team with logistical and financial support will be constituted to explore remote parts of the state for hidden talent. Talent mapping will be undertaken to align sports with popular interests, natural talent, and geographical conditions. Matching the right child to the right sport will be essential, as pushing children into sports they have no interest or aptitude for is counterproductive. Each child will be given a minimum of six chances during selection trials to ensure a fair assessment.

A sports recruitment policy will be developed to offer employment opportunities and financial security to outstanding athletes and coaches, especially national and international medalists/participants. The establishment of High-Performance Centres and Centres of Excellence for prioritised sports is also a priority.

These centres will cater to athletes graduating from Eklavya Schools and entering higher levels of competition. Low-cost, all-weather, modern sports infrastructure will be developed across the state, starting with existing talent hubs, and schools at the block level will be adopted as feeder centres for specific sports. Close coordination with the Education and Health Departments is crucial. District Sports Officers (DSOs) and District Education Officers (DEOs) will work together to ensure the smooth implementation of sports activities in schools, making sports education a mandatory subject that cannot be replaced by extra academic classes.

Financial security through scholarships, cash incentives, and pensions will be offered to athletes and coaches, and felicitations such as "Khel Samman" will recognise those who have significantly contributed to sports development. Finally, the Training of Trainers (TOT) programmes will be conducted regularly, ensuring coaches and retired sports professionals undergo refresher courses to stay updated

**The Honourable Chief Minister Shri Nitish Kumar flagging off the Trophy Tour.**

